

Power of Interest
Online Safety Policy

Version: V0.2

Approved by: Maria Fargher

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The purpose of this policy statement

Power of Interest (POI) works with children and families as part of its activities. Online activity may include debate coaching sessions, online workshops, committee meetings, volunteer communications, mentoring, video conferencing and moderated online discussion.

Debate topics may include controversial or sensitive issues. Sessions will be appropriately moderated, age-appropriate and conducted in accordance with the charity's safeguarding, equality and behaviour policies. Participants must treat differing viewpoints respectfully.

The purpose of this policy statement is to:

- ensure the safety and wellbeing of children and young people is paramount when adults, young people or children are using the internet, social media or mobile devices
- provide staff and volunteers with the overarching principles that guide our approach to online safety

- ensure that, as an organisation, we operate in line with our values and within the law in terms of how we use online devices. The policy statement applies to all staff, volunteers, children and young people and anyone involved in POI's activities.

Legal framework

This policy has been drawn up on the basis of legislation, policy and guidance that seeks to protect children in England. Summaries of the key legislation and guidance are available on:

- online abuse
- bullying
- child protection.

We believe that:

- children and young people should never experience abuse of any kind
- children should be able to use the internet for education and personal development, but safeguards need to be in place to ensure they are kept safe at all times.

We recognise that:

- the online world provides everyone with many opportunities; however it can also present risks and challenges
- we have a duty to ensure that all children, young people and adults involved in our organisation are protected from potential harm online
- we have a responsibility to help keep children and young people safe online, whether or not they are using POI's network and devices

- working in partnership with children, young people, their parents, carers and other agencies is essential in promoting young people's welfare and in helping young people to be responsible in their approach to online safety
- all children, regardless of age, disability, gender reassignment, race, religion or belief, sex or sexual orientation, have the right to equal protection from all types of harm or abuse.

We will seek to keep children and young people safe by:

- The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) has responsibility for overseeing online safety.
- providing clear and specific directions to staff and volunteers on how to behave online through our behaviour code for adults
- supporting and encouraging the young people using our service to use the internet, social media and mobile phones in a way that keeps them safe and shows respect for others
- supporting and encouraging parents and carers to do what they can to keep their children safe online
- developing an online safety agreement for use with young people and their parents or carers
- developing clear and robust procedures to enable us to respond appropriately to any incidents of inappropriate online behaviour, whether by an adult or a child or young person
- Anyone should immediately report:
 - cyberbullying
 - grooming
 - inappropriate messages

- sharing of indecent images
- extremist material
- fake accounts
- impersonation
- suspicious contact

to the Designated Safeguarding Lead.

- reviewing and updating the security of our information systems regularly
- ensuring that user names, logins, email accounts and passwords are used effectively
- ensuring personal information about the adults and children who are involved in our organisation is held securely in accordance with the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018 and shared only as appropriate
- ensuring that images of children, young people and families are used only after their written permission has been obtained, and only for the purpose for which consent has been given
- providing supervision, support and training for staff and volunteers about online safety
- examining and risk assessing any social media platforms and new technologies before they are used within the organisation
- Where AI tools are used, they must be age-appropriate, comply with data protection requirements and not replace appropriate adult supervision
- Online meetings involving children should wherever possible:
 - use approved platforms;
 - have more than one adult present where appropriate;
 - not be recorded unless authorised;

- be scheduled rather than ad hoc;
- follow the same safeguarding expectations as face-to-face activities.
- Audio or video recordings of children will only be made where there is a legitimate organisational need and appropriate consent has been obtained.

If online abuse occurs, we will respond to it by:

- having clear and robust safeguarding procedures in place for responding to abuse (including online abuse)
- providing support and training for all staff and volunteers on dealing with all forms of abuse, including bullying or cyberbullying, emotional abuse, sexting, sexual abuse and sexual exploitation
- making sure our response takes the needs of the person experiencing abuse, any bystanders and our organisation as a whole into account
- reviewing the plan developed to address online abuse at regular intervals, in order to ensure that any problems have been resolved in the long term.

Related policies and procedures

This policy statement should be read alongside our organisational policies and procedures, including:

- child protection
- procedures for responding to concerns about a child or young person's wellbeing dealing with allegations of abuse made against a child or young person

- managing allegations against staff and volunteers
- code of conduct for staff and volunteers
- anti-bullying policy and procedures
- photography and image sharing guidance.

Contact details

Online safety co-ordinator

Name:

Phone/email:

Senior lead for safeguarding and child protection

Name:

Phone/email:

NSPCC Helpline

0808 800 5000

We are committed to reviewing our policy and good practice every 2 years.